Chapter 19: Fight Five. Win Four.

Erik walked onto the field and faced off with Quex.

“To gems dark,” York announced.

Erik knew all too well that Quex didn’t want to just take his shielding down. Quex would be out for blood.

“Begin!” York called.

Quex charged at Erik hoping to strike first and hard, but Erik whipped him back with his whip.

How was Quex going to get close? He could throw his hammer, but it wouldn’t come back.

He charged in ferociously, taking hits from Erik’s whip to get in close. As soon as he did, he began pounding on Erik.

That made Erik’s gem lose some light, but Erik quickly pushed him back and then put up an energy shield.

Quex could hardly get a hit in and was forced off the

field with a dark gem with Erik's gem still glowing pretty brightly. Quex was furious and seethed, "You have humiliated me. I will get revenge."

Likely he would try, but Erik had other things to worry about. Bruis challenged him next.

Bruis was a large Phyrnian who fought with a battle ax. As most Phyrnians, his style was very stand and fight. Erik found him much easier to fight than Quex, and he won fairly quickly, hardly having his gem lose any brightness.

He fought another Aschellean and another Phyrnian and was still left with some light in his gem. It definitely had weakened, but it was still glowing.

His fifth opponent was his bane. He fought a sprite from Alfir whose weapon was throwing stars. As he fought him, he was also getting struck by daggers. That shouldn't have happened, but occasionally a war mage carried extra daggers.

The range weapons were a problem for Erik as he didn't always see them to block, but the daggers did more damage. He didn't even see them, but he could feel them.

He finally figured out what was going on when Lysander whispered, "Go behind, Calix."

Calix… Erik had heard the name before. He hadn't fought much in the arena, so he didn't know Alfir's team well, but he'd heard from Hrod about an Alfirian war mage who could go invisible. Alfir was definitely cheating.

Catria watched in a panic from the side and started to put her hands up to heal Erik in case his shielding went down, but Hrod warned her, “Don’t. York will have you punished.”

Fortunately, the shot that took Erik’s shielding down didn’t do more than a small cut on his arm, and he knew the dagger was coming to his back, so he blocked it.

He immediately put an energy shield between him and where he thought the invisible man was and called, “I’m out.”

York stood up an announced, “Then it is time for your punishment.”

Erik wasn’t eager to be punished, but arguing would get him more lashes, so he went with the lesser war mages who came to collect him.

They removed his shirt, tied him to a post, and began the lashes.

Catria watched and pushed her hands forward, healing him from the first several lashes.

“Those will be done over,” York announced. “Healing is not allowed until after punishment.”

Almost everyone watched in horror as the lashes started again. Yet, many from Ramere were calling “We want blood!” and the Aschelleans sat with smug looks on their faces.

Catria held onto Hrod, but did watch, grabbing around him, discretely pointing her hand toward Erik.

“Don’t get caught,” Hrod warned. “Keep the healing subtle.”

She did, so the wounds did not heal over, but Erik seemed to handle the lashes very well, not crying out in pain.

That infuriated the lesser war mage lashing him who struck harder and seethed, “I’ll break you!”

He didn’t. At the end of the lashings, Erik could still stand, stand in pain, but stand.

Catria ran to him and kissed him. Besides the healing, it was a sign of hope. Most of the crowd cheered for them.

Erik waved to the crowd and walked off the field as York announced the next fight, Phyrn verses Cruia, once again fighting to get Xena back.

“Shouldn’t there be a limit to how many times a team can attack for the same thing?” Dillion asked. “We’ve already won this fight more than once.”

“The council will discuss that,” York answered. “Now, take the field.”

The battle was three verses three. Dillion had to fight as the captain. Hernry wanted to fight, as he was protecting Xena.

Dillion looked over at Erik, noted, “You just fought,” and called, “Walker, you’re up.”

Walker would be good, as he was strong and fought with two fire sticks, but Erik hurried over, assuring

Dillion, “I can fight. Catria connects well with me, so I’m healed.” He held his bracer up to show it was full.

“Then you are up,” Dillion decided.

Dillion, Erik, and Henry took the field and faced off with Slayde, Payne, and Bantha, who was chosen because her weapon was bow and arrows, and distance weapons seemed to work better against Erik than close range ones.

She really didn’t get hits. Erik fought defensively, protecting himself and his teammates and let them dish out the damage.

Phyrn did get a few hits in, as Erik couldn’t put up energy shields when war mages were fighting close up, but he helped with his whip too.

Overall, the fight was simple for Cruia, and all three of the war mages from Phyrn had their gems go dark before one from Cruia did.

Cruia made no nasty comments when they won, but Erik tipped his hat and told Slayde, “It was fun. We’ll be back next time.” He then turned to Henry and suggested, “Hurry back to Xena so she can give you your hero’s kiss.”

He didn’t realize that Slayde could hear that, but Slayde became so enraged at the comment that he charged at Erik and tackled him.

Dillion and Henry came over and pulled him off Erik, and York chided, “Enough! Slayde and Erik, you will both be punished for the fight!”

“I didn’t fight,” Erik pointed out. “He tackled me, and I’m not letting my shielding go down to punish me again.”

York motioned for the crowd to be quiet for a moment while he thought. Then he decided, “Slayde attacked. Only he will be punished.”

Cruia left the field as Slayde was taken, cursing the entire way, to be punished.

Erik didn’t enjoy seeing Slayde punished. Slayde was cruel, but still, the punishment was brutal.

“He’s going to be really mad and come back after us,” Dillion noted to Erik as the punishment ended. “We need to watch our backs.”

Erik nodded, but replied, “I’ll be on team Terrian before the next battle day. I think Catria is going to need protection too. We should move up the wedding.”

“Perhaps,” Dillion agreed. “On either team, I think you’ve got excitement ahead of you. You really scared people today and made some big enemies.”

“I know,” Erik agreed, “but what else could I do? Honestly, I’m not scared of the arena. I’m scared of whoever got past my shielding with the arrow. Likely, it was someone from Alfir. They have some terrifying abilities.”